

Philadelphia Museum Closure Prompts Funding Offer and Planned City Hearings

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Philadelphia's Academy of Natural Sciences Museum has closed, leaving families without a familiar place to explore dinosaurs, animals and natural history. After a September 1 announcement gave visitors one month's notice, thousands came for final visits before the September 30 closure.

Founded in 1812, the Academy opened to the public in 1828. It became the first institution in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton in 1868. Generations of children have since visited its exhibits, which also included animal **dioramas**, live animals and changing displays. **Dioramas** are scenes that show animals in settings resembling their habitats.

Drexel University, which assumed financial responsibility for the Academy in 2011, said costs had risen and attendance had declined after the pandemic. The university has also faced its own financial difficulties. The museum reduced staffing and hours in 2025 and cancelled its 2026 summer camp.

Attendance surged during the final weeks. **Revenue** was more than 20 times higher than during the previous September. Supporters organized rallies, marches and an online **petition** with more than 114,000 signatures. Some criticized Drexel for giving little warning and not explaining what keeping the museum open would cost.

Less than a week before closing, the William Penn Foundation offered a year of bridge funding. That means temporary financial support while a longer solution is explored. Drexel said it was exploring the possibility of working with the foundation, but needed a **sustainable** long-term plan before considering reopening.

The Academy's collection contains more than 19 million specimens, including Thomas Jefferson's fossils and plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark. It also holds 73,000 **holotype** specimens: reference samples scientists use to define and name species. Drexel said it would preserve access for students and researchers, although access for the public remains uncertain.

Philadelphia's city council has proposed **zoning** changes that would make selling the building or converting it to other uses more difficult. It also plans public hearings to investigate the closure and possible solutions. Whether or when the museum will reopen remains uncertain.

Word Treasure

dioramas -- Displays showing animals in scenes resembling their habitats.

revenue -- Money received by an organization.

petition -- A written request signed by people who support it.

sustainable -- Able to continue over the long term.

holotype -- A reference specimen used to define and name a species.

zoning -- Rules about how land and buildings may be used.

Background you need

The Academy opened to the public in 1828 and displayed a dinosaur skeleton in 1868. Its collection includes Thomas Jefferson's fossils and plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark.

Bridge funding provides temporary support while a longer solution is explored.

Break it down

Opens with the closure and the final visits.

Provides historical context and explains dioramas.

Reports financial difficulties and earlier service reductions.

Describes increased attendance and supporters' criticism.

Explains the funding offer and Drexel's reopening condition.

Describes the scientific collection and uncertainty about public access.

Ends with proposed zoning changes, hearings and an uncertain reopening.

Why it matters

The closure removes a familiar learning destination for families. The funding offer and planned hearings concern whether public visits can resume, while Drexel says students and researchers will retain collection access.

Test what you remember

1. What changed during the museum's final weeks?

- ☐ (A) The summer camp restarted.
- ☐ (B) Attendance rose sharply.
- ☐ (C) The museum extended its hours.
- ☐ (D) Its financial responsibility changed.

2. What are the dioramas described in the article?

- ☐ (A) Records of museum ticket sales.
- ☐ (B) Plans for changes to museum buildings.
- ☐ (C) Scenes of animals in habitat-like settings.
- ☐ (D) Samples used to name new species.

3. What did some supporters criticize Drexel for?

- ☐ (A) Changing the dinosaur displays too often.
- ☐ (B) Holding too many public hearings.
- ☐ (C) Giving little warning about the closure.
- ☐ (D) Offering too many summer camp places.

4. What was the purpose of the offered bridge funding?

- ☐ (A) To support a search for a lasting solution.
- ☐ (B) To fund a permanent expansion of the building.
- ☐ (C) To pay for moving the museum to another city.
- ☐ (D) To replace the collection with new exhibits.

5. What do scientists use holotype specimens for?

- ☐ (A) Planning staffing and opening hours.
- ☐ (B) Defining species and giving them names.
- ☐ (C) Measuring attendance and ticket revenue.
- ☐ (D) Setting zoning rules and building uses.

6. What would the proposed zoning changes make more difficult?

- ☐ (A) Organizing or signing the supporters' petition.
- ☐ (B) Studying or cataloging the scientific specimens.
- ☐ (C) Planning or attending the public hearings.
- ☐ (D) Selling or changing the use of the building.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: D

1. Drexel University: Drexel reported rising costs and declining attendance after the pandemic. It said it was exploring cooperation with the foundation and required a sustainable long-term plan before considering reopening.